

condition and, also randomly, were rewarded with either a descending or a random sequence of outcomes.

All participants played 14 hands of “Red & Black,” using four cards from a standard poker deck. Each card was presented facedown on the screen, and subjects were asked to wager as to whether a chosen card matched a selected, target color. Each player began with 50 chips. In each hand, participants could wager between zero and five chips; winning increased the participant’s total stock of chips by the wagered amount. Likewise, following a lost hand, a player’s supply of chips automatically decreased by the wagered amount. The odds of winning each hand were calibrated at 50:50.

Participants randomly assigned to the high-involvement condition were allowed to “shuffle” and “deal” the cards themselves. They could also choose, in each hand, the target color and the amount wagered. After the high-involvement participants chose their cards, the computer revealed each result accordingly. This sequence repeated over the course of 14 trials. The high-involvement condition was designed to maximize the participants’ perception that they were controlling the game.

In the low-involvement condition, the computer shuffled and dealt the cards. The participants chose the amounts wagered, but the computer randomly selected the card on which the outcome of each hand would rest.

The descending outcome sequence was designed to maximize the illusion of control, letting the majority of successful outcomes occur during the first seven trials.³ The descending sequence, for example, consisted of the outcomes depicted in Figure 8.1.

The random outcome sequence was designed to minimize the illusion of control by spacing the successful outcomes more evenly over the course of the 14 trials. Figure 8.2 demonstrates a sample distribution.

Ultimately, participants in the high-involvement condition tended to wager more chips on each hand than did participants in the low-involvement condition. Moreover, in the low-involvement condition, wagers did not differ reliably as a function of distributed feature composition (DFC)—in other words, participants receiving the descending sequence of outcomes

Win	Win	Lose	Win	Win	Win	Lose	Lose	Win	Lose	Lose	Lose	Win	Lose
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FIGURE 8.1 A Sample Distribution of the Descending Outcome Sequence in “The Illusion of Control: What’s Luck Got to Do with It?”

Source: Andrea Breinholt and Lynnette A. Dalrymple, “The Illusion of Control: What’s Luck Got to Do with It?” *The Myriad: Westminster College Undergraduate Academic Journal* (Summer 2004).